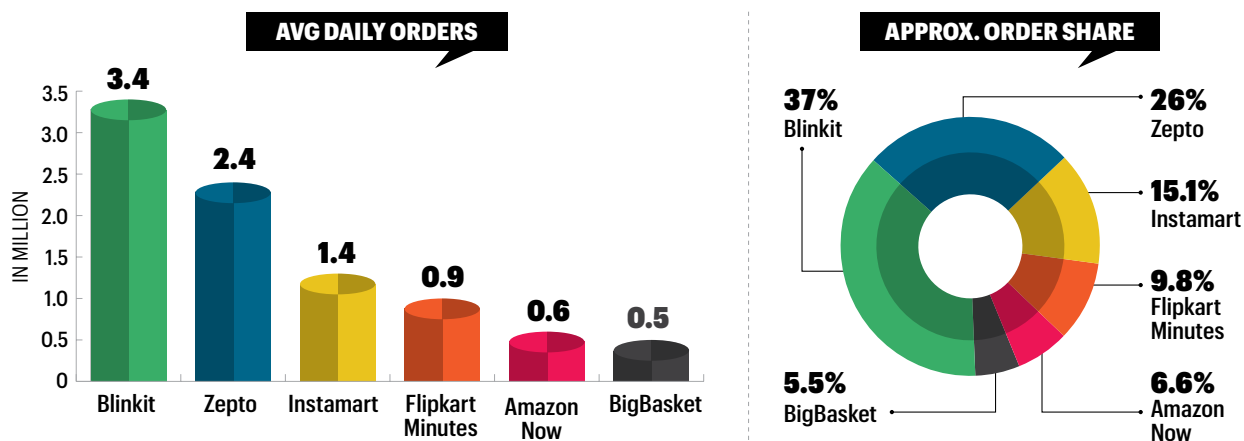


THE BATTLE FOR THE BASKET

Blinkit remains ahead on order volumes as Zepto, Instamart and new challengers fight for market share



NOTE MARKET SHARE REFERS TO SHARE OF ESTIMATED AVERAGE DAILY ORDERS, NOT GMV/REVENUE. FIGURES ARE BASED ON INDUSTRY ESTIMATES AS OF AUG 2026. **SOURCE** DATUM INTELLIGENCE

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commerce and will have to be learned,” says Killa.

In smaller towns, one dark store could serve an entire town, with 30-minute deliveries replacing the 10-15-minute promise.

But there is a catch: a market that can support quick commerce may not support several competing platforms.

Blinkit is already present in 300 cities with over 2,400 dark stores. Instamart is present in 128 cities with 1,181 dark stores, while Zepto stays ahead with 61 cities and 1,225 dark stores. Gupta says Minutes is on track to reach around 1,500 micro-fulfilment centres across more than 150 cities “very soon”.

The deep pockets of e-commerce giants give them the ability to spend. However, their biggest disadvantage would be customer habit.

Meena argues that Amazon and Flipkart are entering a market where consumers have already developed strong preferences for incumbent apps. “Deep pockets alone cannot beat established platforms. In quick commerce, customer stickiness and habit matter more,” he says.

Gupta says that repeat purchases for Minutes have risen more than 20% in the past one year as it seeks

to leverage the broader Flipkart customer ecosystem rather than rely solely on fresh customer acquisition.

Killa sees another possible outcome. Amazon and Flipkart could expand the market by moving more traditional retail and e-commerce demand online. But their entry could also put pressure on incumbents’ growth and profitability.

While the market may be getting bigger and the economics may be getting better, competition could keep making profitable scale harder to achieve.

Consumer behaviour is changing with rising smartphone and internet adoption, and quick commerce is increasingly influencing what—and how—Indians shop. There is, therefore, a credible argument that India can accommodate more than the three players that dominated the first phase.

The winners of the next phase will not necessarily be the companies with the most stores, the fastest delivery times or even the largest order volumes. They will be the ones that can convert density into productivity, grocery frequency into higher-margin baskets, and scale into sustainable cash generation. **BT**

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